

Concept tags for work in Week 7: technology as a teammate, useful friction, candor without authority, curation as self-knowledge, body of work, invisible systems made visible, service design under pressure

This week we had the opportunity to speak with Chengwei Liu, a researcher whose current work focuses on how to be a smart contrarian. Before starting here at Dartmouth, I can admit I was not always the best at hearing other people's criticisms or critiques or challenging ideas of my own. Since then, with the amount of sometimes grueling feedback on my work from professors and working on more serious projects with my peers, I have learned to think critically about my own ideas and welcome constructive criticism. I know now, and that is partially thanks to the work and presentations we have done throughout this course, feedback and fresh ideas from peers only serves to make my idea better. Even if we didn't have much time to build on our projects after the crit sessions with the class, I took in the ideas and observations my peers had and stored them in what I call my "designers toolkit." Seeds of our classes feedback shaped the way I approached every project thereafter. I am a better designer for accepting unfamiliar ideas that may have opposed my own ways of thinking, as we discussed in class and with Chengwei Liu this week.

This smart contrarian practice really set in this week as I worked on developing ideas for my final project. I knew that I didn't want to continue my work from week 3 because I couldn't see a design I could create there. I struggled for a while trying to think of what interested me, what real world challenge I wanted to tackle, and what I could realistically accomplish in three short weeks. At first I thought of creating a project with another HCD professor or collaborating with the O-Farm on a sustainable education themed project (which would blend my passion for teaching and the Dartmouth community). I ruled these ideas out pretty quickly, thinking that they were too large or too much work to do on my own. I saw my peers partnering up and expanding on their ideas on the whiteboard walls at the beginning of the week and just felt lost. I knew I had to come up with an idea soon, but nothing was speaking to me.

Finally by Wednesday, I thought back to the smart contrarian. Would a smart contrarian rule out their only ideas simply because they didn't think they would have time to complete them? No. A smart contrarian would sit down, and analyze what drew them to those ideas in the first place. I liked the idea of building something for the Dartmouth community and engaging with other students. I thought back to all of the projects we had worked on throughout the term and what patterns of design emerged – what was I passionate about and drawn to? This helped me narrow my final project idea down to

something that could blend Dartmouth, peer engagement, and service design. Looking at all of the projects I had stored in a folder on my desktop, for this class and others that I had forgotten about, I thought that there should be somewhere to display these. Even if you did not want to make these projects real, humans are drawn to validation. It feels nice to hear that something you spend days, or maybe weeks working on, was valuable and a good idea. This is where my idea for D.I.P.S. (The Dartmouth Innovative Project Studio) was born.

I knew for this, I would want to work with Claude Code, or something similar, to bring my idea to life. I decided to take Professor Eagle's advice and discuss my idea with AI and get them to be my objective Smart Contrarian. Quickly I realized that while AI is often a helpful tool, it is also the biggest "yes man." You run your ideas by it and suddenly everything you pitch is amazing. But when you take the time to write a prompt giving you the pros and cons of your idea and to pitch places where you may want to expand on a certain aspect, it does a fine job. This was my experience working with Claude Code for the first time and running through some test prompts and seeing what worked and what didn't. Quickly I realized that even though I wasn't writing code myself, this was not going to be a quick and easy task. This is when I created my, now informed, outline of what I wanted and could feasibly accomplish in my V1, V2, and V3:

V1	V2	V3
Aiming for completed, static, design of the home page and portfolio/project pages. Galley style, each project in a museum frame hung up on the "wall." By this point I should also have my own portfolio completed and ready to be uploaded as a test, this can also be used to mockup how the portfolio/project pages will look once the user clicks on a frame.	A beta of the Claude Coded website that is ready to be tested with real uploads of my past projects. I can also include the work of some of my interviewees if they agree. The filter, tags, comment box, and search bar are all functional.	After user tests and feedback, the site should be live. All of the functions should work immediately and directions to use the website should be easily understood. At this point, I can create a small launch and share the site with my friends or interviewees and see how real students can engage with the platform.